

PRACTICAL GUIDE

Whisper for transcription

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READ THIS FIRST

Whisper produces an **automatic transcript**, but every transcript must be proofread and corrected before it is used as research data.

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1 About this guide

This guide describes, step by step, how to use Whisper to transcribe audio recordings automatically in the lab. It covers the whole workflow: preparing the project and the audio files, running the transcription, monitoring it, then retrieving and checking the transcripts.

It is written for anyone who records interviews and needs a first transcript, **intended to be proofread and corrected as required**. No programming experience is needed: every command is given ready to copy.

TIME NEEDED	WHERE	WHAT YOU GET
≈ 5 min to set up	The lab transcription workstation — room A4.340	One text file per recording, to proofread and correct

2 Before you start

2.1 — Access checks

- 01** You have contacted Laurent Ott to obtain an account allowing you to book the workstation at: https://scalab-apps.univ-lille.fr/grr/month_all.php?area=1&day=16&year=2026&month=09 located in room A4.340.
- 02** Your recordings are saved on a USB stick.

3 The workflow at a glance

- 01 Prepare the audio files**
Copy the recordings onto the workstation. §4
 - 02 Copy the script and set up the folder**
Copy “Script Whisper”, rename it, put the audio files next to it. §5
 - 03 Run the transcription**
Open your own script in Spyder, set the folder and extension, run (F5). §6
 - 04 Monitor progress**
The console prints segments as it goes; do not close it. §7
 - 05 Retrieve the transcripts**
Open the output folder, check the start and end of the text. §8
 - 06 Proofread and correct**
Mandatory before analysis: proper nouns, technical terms, overlapping speech. §8.3
-

4 Preparing the recordings

Transcript quality depends directly on recording quality. Clean audio cuts proofreading time sharply.

IF POSSIBLE

Place the microphone within a metre of the speakers
Limit background noise (ventilation, corridor)
Run a 20-second test before the interview

AVOID

Recording with a laptop's built-in microphone
Highly reverberant rooms

4.1 — Accepted formats and conversion

Whisper reads most common formats through ffmpeg: .wav .mp3 .m4a .flac .ogg .mp4 .mov, and so on.

5 Organising project folders

5.1 — Copying the Whisper script

- 01** Copy the **Script Whisper** file into the folder that will hold the audio files and/or the project folders. This comes first: the script must sit *at the same level* as the audio folders.
- 02** Rename the copy as you like, for example with your initials (ERtemp.py). Keep the .py extension.
- 03** Create the audio folder(s) next to the script, then put the recordings to transcribe inside.

5.2 — Folder structure

One folder per project, always the same structure. That is what lets you run the same code from one project to the next, changing nothing but the folder name.

```
~/Transcripts/  
├─ Project_01/  
│   ├─ Audio/           ← recordings to transcribe  
│   └─ Transcripts/     ← Whisper output  
├─ Project_02/  
│   ├─ Audio/  
│   └─ Transcripts/  
│       └─ Log.csv  
└─ Project_03/  
    └─ ...
```

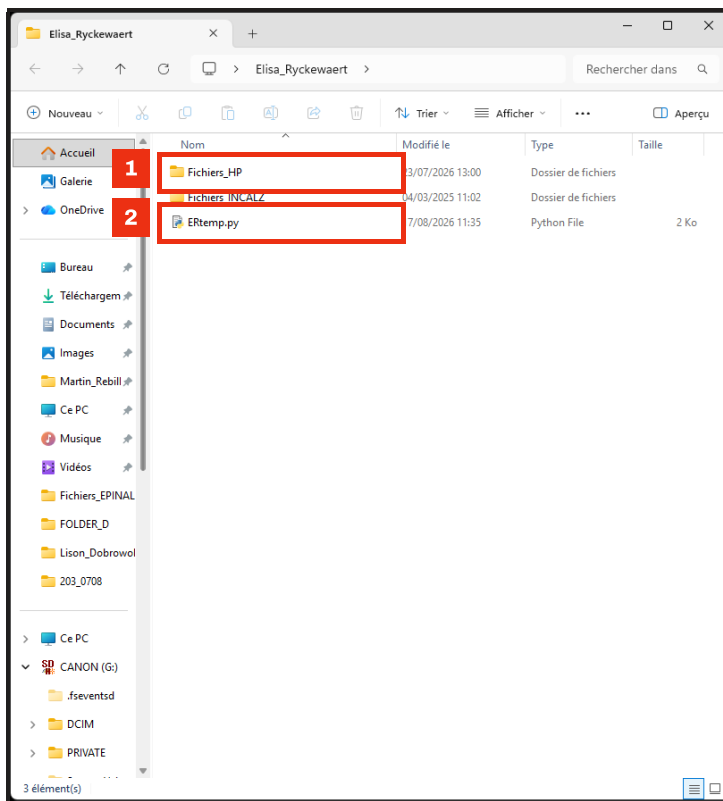


Fig. 1 – The working folder in File Explorer: the audio folder (1) and the renamed copy of the script (2), at the same level.

6 Running the transcription

6.1 — Opening Spyder

- 01** Open Spyder, then **File > Open** and select *your* script, in the folder prepared in §5.
- 02** Check the tab name and the path shown above the editor: they must match your script and your folder.

MAKE SURE IT IS YOUR SCRIPT

On a shared workstation, Spyder often reopens the last script used, which may belong to a colleague. Editing or running it would transcribe their files or overwrite their settings. Always check the path before running.

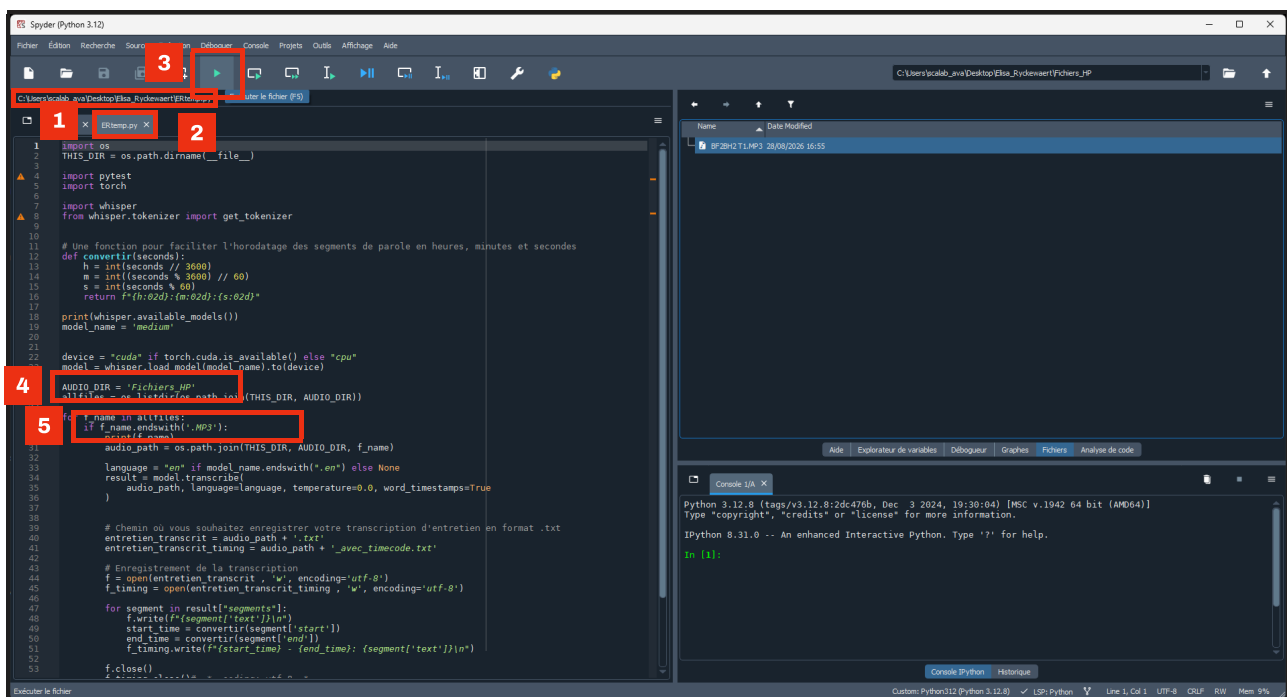


Fig. 2 — Spyder open on your own script: tab name (1) and file path (2) to check, the “Run file (F5)” button (3), and the two parameters from §6.2: audio folder (4) and extension (5).

6.2 — Setting the script's two parameters

Only two lines need adjusting before each run. The rest of the script stays the same.

```
AUDIO_DIR = 'Fichiers_HP'      ← 1

...

if f_name.endswith('.MP3'):    ← 2
```

NO.	LINE	WHAT TO CHANGE
1	<code>AUDIO_DIR = 'Fichiers_HP'</code>	Replace Fichiers_HP with the exact name of the folder holding the audio files to transcribe, between straight quotes ' '.
2	<code>if f_name.endswith('.MP3'):</code>	Replace MP3 with your files' extension: .mp4, .wav, .m4a... Match upper and lower case exactly as in the file names: .MP3 and .mp3 are not the same.

BEFORE EVERY RUN

Check that both parameters point to the right folder and the right extension. You can change them as often as needed depending on the files to process; save the script (Ctrl+S) after editing.

6.3 — Transcribing a single file

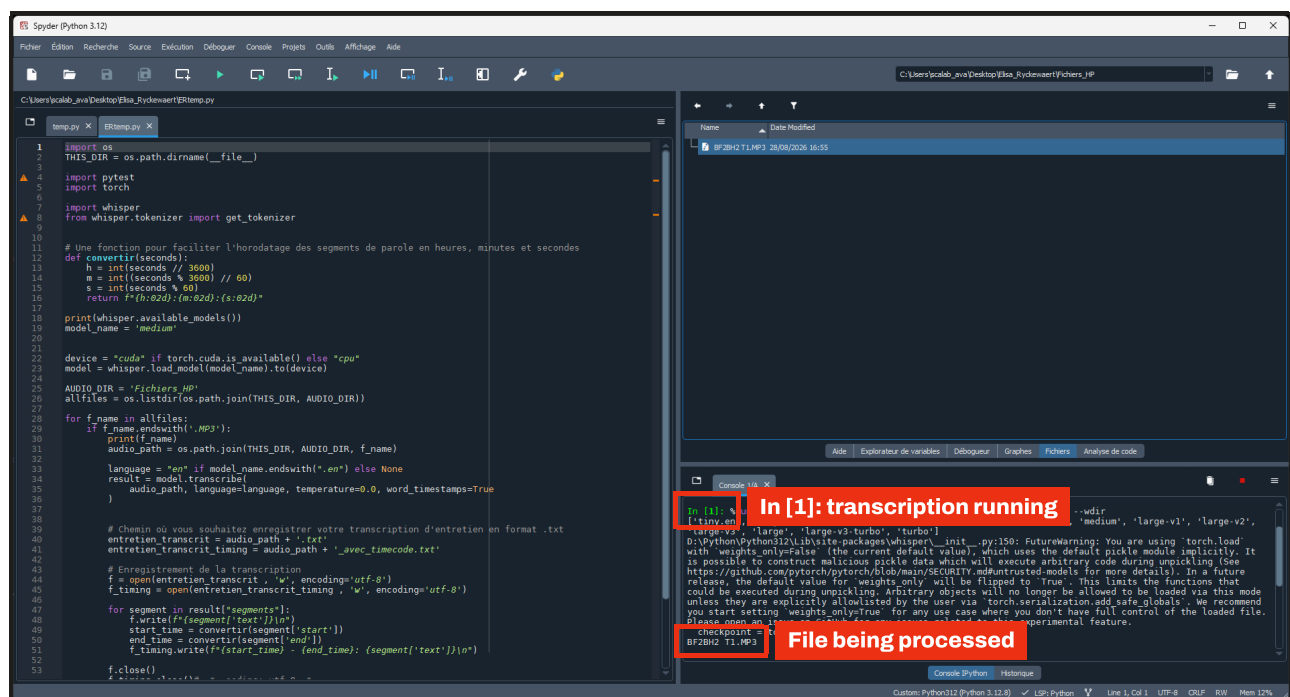


Fig. 3 — Running: the console lists the available models, then the name of the file being processed. As long as In [1]: has no new prompt below it, the transcription is still going.

6.4 — Transcribing every file in a project

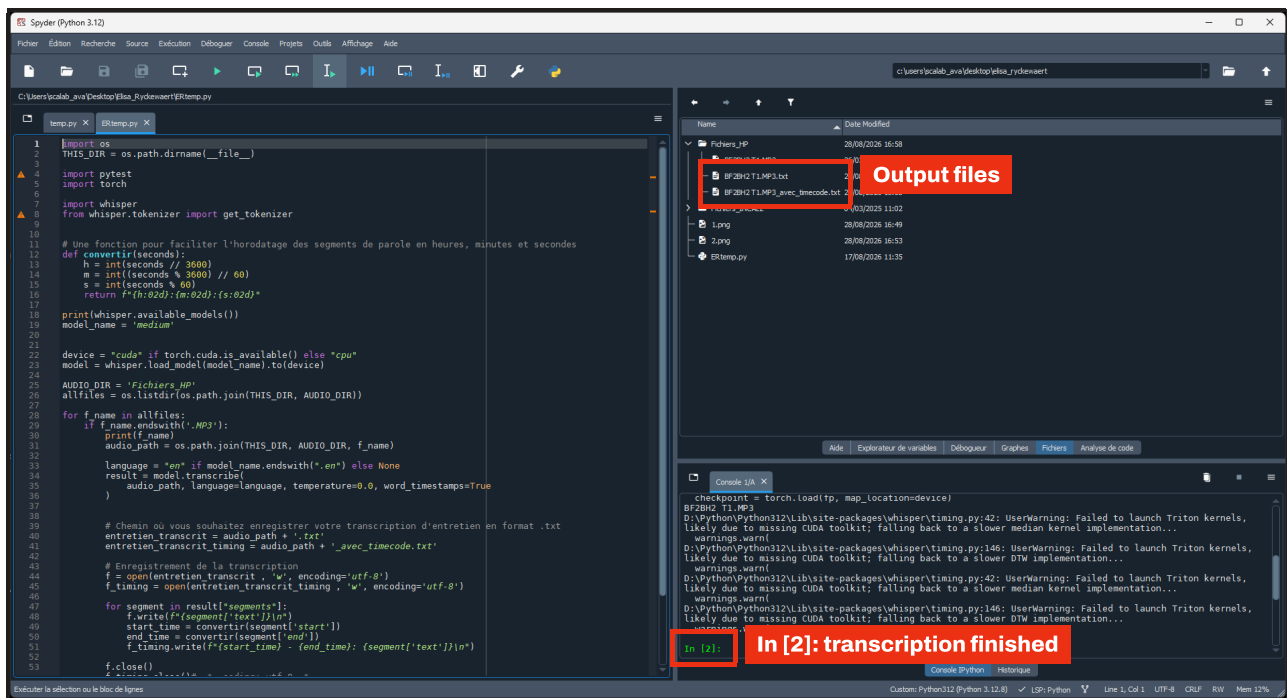


Fig. 4 – Transcription finished: a new In [2]: prompt appears in the console, and the .txt files show up in Fichiers_HP (Files tab).

KNOWING WHEN THE TRANSCRIPTION IS DONE

At launch, the console shows In [1]: followed by the command: the transcription is running, so wait. It is finished when a new empty prompt appears at the bottom of the console: In [2]:, then In [3]: and so on, the number going up with each run of the script. *UserWarning* messages shown in the meantime are normal and do not stop the process.

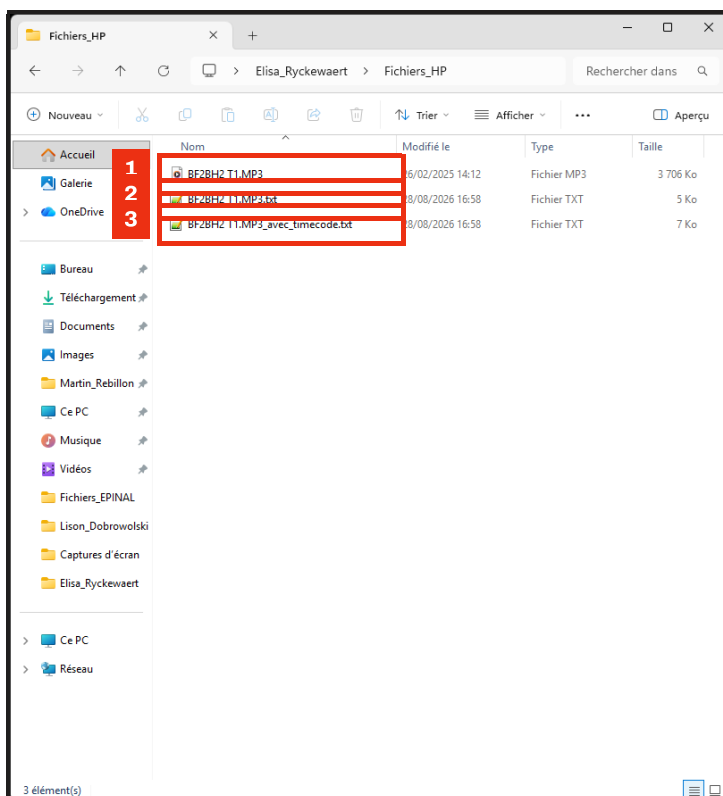


Fig. 5 – The result in File Explorer: the original audio (1), the .txt transcript (2) and its timestamped

version (3).

7 Monitoring progress

WHILE IT RUNS

Do not close the console and do not let the workstation go to sleep.

If the process seems stuck, in this order:

- 01 Wait a few minutes: a long silence in the audio slows the model down considerably.
- 02 Read the last line in the console: an error message there is almost always explicit.
- 03 Check that the audio file opens normally in a player.
- 04 Check the folder path and the exact spelling of the file name.
- 05 Stop with Ctrl + C, then rerun on a single file to isolate the problem.

8 Retrieving and checking the transcript

8.1 — Where the files are

In the folder that holds your original audio recordings.

8.2 — Quick check (two minutes per file)

- 01 The file exists and its name matches the audio.
- 02 The text is readable and in the expected language.
- 03 The opening lines match the real start of the interview.
- 04 The end is not cut off, and no sentence repeats in a loop.

8.3 — Proofreading and correction

Proofreading is essential in order to:

- anonymise names of people and places
- check medical or scientific terminology
- acronyms and abbreviations.
- inaudible phrases rendered as an approximation
- overlapping speech
- background noise read as words
- unmarked speaker changes

EXAMPLES

[inaudible 00:12:31] — unintelligible passage, with the timestamp from the .srt

I: / P: — interviewer / participant, added during proofreading

[laughs], [silence] — non-verbal elements kept by the protocol

<P012> — systematic pseudonymisation of proper nouns before analysis

9 Processing several files and projects

You can run several transcriptions at once simply by dropping all the interviews you want into the folder. Starting the transcription will then process every file in that folder automatically. One point to watch: if the formats differ, Whisper will only transcribe the files matching the format stated in the code — you will have to repeat the operation, changing the format name each time.

10 References

Chitour, Y., & Boelaert, J. (n.d.). *Whisper pour retranscrire des entretiens* [Using Whisper to transcribe interviews]. Computational Social Science, CNRS. <https://www.css.cnrs.fr/whisper-pour-retranscrire-des-entretiens/>

Rosenberg, J., et al. (2024). Automated transcription of interviews in qualitative research using artificial intelligence: A simple guide. *Journal of Surgery Research and Practice*, 5(2), 1–6. <https://doi.org/10.46889/JSRP.2024.5204>

A question, an error not listed here, a command worth adding? Report it for the next version of this guide.

END OF GUIDE